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LETTERS TO MY SON

On Character

16 letters

Father

A father's letters, worth keeping.

A word before you begin

My son,

Reputation is what men say of you; character is what you are
unwatched. These letters are on becoming a man worth
trusting.

Read one a day. Sit with it. Let it change one small thing in
how you live.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

A fool flatters; a wise man observes.

Praise costs nothing and means even less. Watch what a man does when praise is gone.

Trust the eyes, not the tongue.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Manners open more doors than talent ever will.

The gifted man with no grace dies unknown. The gracious man with little gift is welcomed everywhere.

Polish the way you treat people; it carries you further than skill.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Be wiser than other men if you can, but never tell them so.

The man who proves his cleverness in every room is
trusted in none.

Let them discover your depth; it is worth more found than
shown.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

What progress have you made, if you are still the same in private?

The man who behaves only when watched has built nothing of his own.

Be the same man in the dark as in the light.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Each person must become a flourishing individual before they can serve the whole.

A family of strong individuals is strong. A family that swallows its individuals is brittle.

Become fully yourself; that is your contribution.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

An iron will behind a calm face wins more than force ever does.

The man who masters his temper in the moment masters the men who cannot.

Rule the flash of anger and you rule the room.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Ask not what you own, but what you have become.

Possessions answer to fortune; character answers only to you.

Measure the year by who you are, not what you gathered.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Become a flourishing individual before you try to carry the whole.

You cannot pour from an empty cup, nor hold a family from a hollow self.

Build the man first; the duty fits him after.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Manners open the doors that talent only knocks on.

The gifted boor dies unknown; the gracious man is welcomed everywhere.

Polish how you treat people; it carries you furthest.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Apologise fast, mean it, and do not repeat the fault.

A clean apology is rarer and stronger than a clever excuse.

Own it plainly and move forward changed.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Promises are cheap to make and dear to keep.

Better to promise little and deliver fully than the reverse.

Say less; do more.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

No man can wear a mask for long; the face grows to fit it.

Pretend to be good long enough and you may have to become it, or be unmasked.

Choose the face you would not mind growing into.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Let your actions be loud and your boasting silent.

The man who must announce his worth has already cast
doubt on it.

Do the thing; let it speak.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Anger is a brief madness you can refuse to enter.

The insult lands only if you agree to carry it.

Set it down before it sets the day on fire.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

A man's worth is not his balance sheet but his bearing under pressure.

Wealth reveals character; it rarely creates it.

Build the bearing first; the rest is weather.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Be slow to anger and slower to show it.

The man who is mastered by a moment is owned by anyone who can provoke him.

Hold the reaction; it is your last free territory.

Yours faithfully,

Father

Keep going

If these served you, there is more.

- A new letter every day — @letters_to_son_eng
- The weekly letter — comment LETTERS to join.
- The full collection and printed keepsakes — coming soon.

Carry these well. One day you may write your own.

Yours faithfully,

Father